

Error down under

AS I HAVE MENTIONED IN PREVIOUS COLUMNS, I RESIDE IN AUSTRALIA, THOUGH I VERY RARELY TALK ABOUT WHAT'S HAPPENING HERE. This month, I'm breaking from tradition and not just talking about something Australian, but *ugh* something political! I do this because I think it's relevant to all media houses like Digit across the globe.

Google just threatened to shut off its search functionality for Australia! It even ran an "experiment" that dropped all Australian news media from its search results, for one percent of Australian searchers. A heck of a lot of those unlucky one percent of people seemed to be journalists... nope nothing fishy about that at all... this was not Google flexing its muscles and firing a warning shot... merely an experiment.

Why? That's a several million dollar question! Because the Australian Government is considering a bill that would change the laws and make Google and Facebook (and others) pay media houses for the content they make, which then gets shared or clicked on these giant platforms.

The proposed law is called the News Media Bargaining Code, and it basically states that Australian news media lack bargaining power with the likes of Google and Facebook and others, who benefit from the content that the media houses produce and have taken away their advertising revenue.

The problem that media houses have is that Google shows snippets of a news story, has secret algorithms that seems to rank news arbitrarily, and basically tech giants are all powerful. In Facebook's case the news is shared widely and can even be copy-pasted by users of Facebook without crediting or linking to the original source, and then to top it all, Facebook shows those same users ads between the stories that media houses put out, and even charges the media houses themselves fees to be shown to more users!

With Digit, there are times we have been the first to report a news story in technology, which is then copied by bloggers, automated aggregator sites and the like. Sometimes in both Google Search and Google Discover, these sites who copied our story show up above us in ranking!

From Google's perspective, they claim they are merely a search engine, and they only show links to content and leave it to the users to decide whether to click or not. Google Australia's chief appeared in a video to tell Australians that the

proposed law was like a friend asking you for a suggestion on where to buy coffee, and you tell your friend of four or five good cafes near your house, and then those cafes all send you a bill for recommending them.

Yeah, not quite true is it Google? It's more like me being the sole person anyone on the internet asks for coffee recommendations, and I throw you a sorted list with no context or information about how and why I selected the shops on that list. Then I charge those shops money to appear first on the list (as an ad) for as many searchers as they can afford to target. On top of that, if those shops are trying to add value by informing people about how to make a good cup of coffee at home, I start telling people the answer without even sending those people to the coffee shop! Plus, all of the local ads that people used to place in coffee shops by paying them a small fee... I now start showing to people searching for coffee, thus becoming a direct competitor in that narrow sense.

In terms of news and journalism, ads are used to pay for the expenses of producing quality content, and they're drying up. Google and Facebook and the likes have taken away advertising from media houses. If Digit writes a review about the latest GPU, and you come and visit that page, either via a search result that Google showed, or via a Facebook post that we or someone else posted, both Google and Facebook are tracking you. They know that you wanted to read about the latest phone. They track you all over the internet and show you ads about offers on that phone, and each time they show you that ad, they earn money from the advertiser. You might decide to buy that phone because you liked the rating Digit gave it, but the tech giants get all the credit. Digit gets nothing for the work it did, in fact, it has to pay Facebook to promote our review to more people, and we have to hope that some site that copies our review doesn't rank higher than us because of Google's moody algorithm!

Overall, this is an interesting fight, and way too complex to cover in a short column. You should follow the story, because something tells me both Google and Facebook might actually stop all search and news in Australia, because Australia is a tiny market for them. Now if India was to come up with a similar law, that would be something that would send ripples across the globe!! 🇮🇳



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